

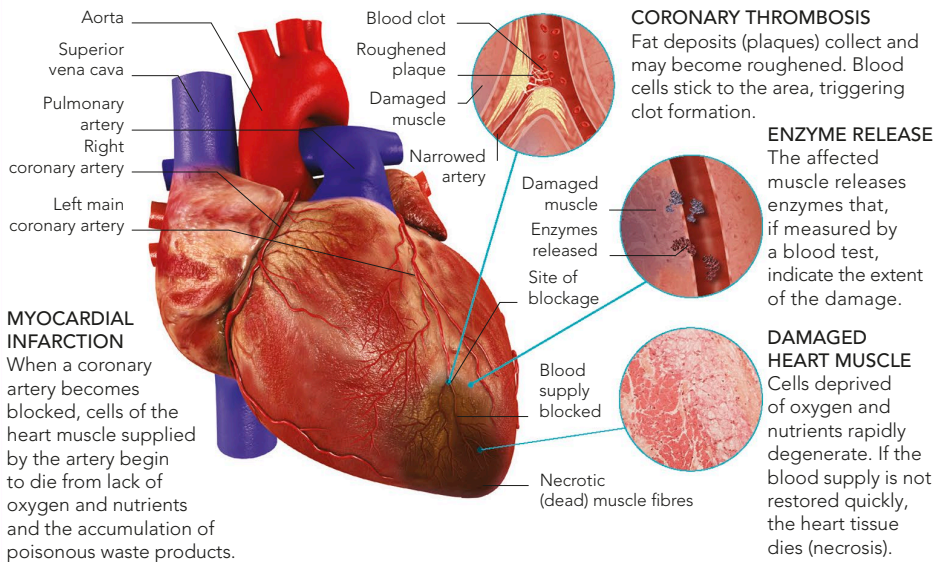
CARDIOVASCULAR DISORDERS

DISORDERS OF THE CARDIOVASCULAR SYSTEM MAY AFFECT THE HEART ITSELF, CAUSING STRUCTURAL DAMAGE OR DISRUPTING HEART RHYTHM. BLOCKAGES IN BLOOD VESSELS CAN STARVE TISSUES OF OXYGEN, LEADING TO SERIOUS PROBLEMS ANYWHERE IN THE BODY.

HEART ATTACK

A heart attack (myocardial infarction) is the result of coronary heart disease due to atherosclerosis (see opposite), and the subsequent formation of a blood clot, or thrombus. Once formed, the clot can completely block blood flow to an area of heart muscle, starving it of oxygen and eventually causing tissue death. If possible, the blood flow

must be restored to the damaged cells as quickly as possible. A heart attack usually occurs suddenly, with little or no warning. The chest pain is usually severe, is not necessarily brought on by exertion, and persists despite resting. A heart attack can also cause sweating, shortness of breath, nausea, and loss of consciousness.



ANGINA

Angina is caused by a temporarily inadequate supply of blood to the heart muscle, usually because of arterial narrowing as a result of atherosclerosis (see opposite). The pain most often occurs when the heart's workload is increased, for example with exercise, and fades with rest. Other triggers of angina are stress, cold weather, or a

large meal. An attack of angina typically begins with a heavy, constricting pain behind the breastbone. This can spread into the throat and jaw, and down into the arms, especially the left one. The pain usually subsides within about 10-15 minutes. People with angina often take medication to dilate (widen) the coronary arteries.